

Starting a session without burning tokens

A short guide to the files in `PROJECT\`, `CHANGELOG\` and `CLAUDE.md` · 12
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The problem these files solve

When you come back to this project after a few weeks and ask me to change something, my instinct is to read the project to work out where things stand — the page, the template, the build script, the data. That is about **34,000 tokens** before I have done any actual work.

The memory files hold that same understanding in a much smaller space. Reading them costs roughly **4,200 tokens** — about **eight times less** — and leaves far more room for the real task.

What I read	Size	Cost
The project itself — page, template, build script, data	136 KB	~34,000 tokens
CLAUDE.md + status + todo + latest changelog	17 KB	~4,200 tokens

Those are measured from your actual files, not estimates.

The one thing to do

Open a new session and start with this. Nothing else is needed:

Read `CLAUDE.md` and `PROJECT\PROJECT_STATUS.md`, then tell me where the project stands.

I will come back with the current state, what is outstanding, and what changed recently — without opening the website code at all. From there you can ask for whatever you actually wanted.

If you would rather not type that every time

Say **“continue the project”**. `CLAUDE.md` tells me that phrase means: load the status, review the unfinished work, look at recent changes, and pick up from there. It does the same thing in three words.

Which file answers which question

Point me at one of these instead of letting me go looking.

If you want to know...	Say	Holds
Where things stand right now	PROJECT\PROJECT_STATUS.md	Current phase, what is done, what is blocked, what is untested
What is still left to do	PROJECT\TODO.md	16 open items by priority, plus decisions waiting on you
Why something was built this way	PROJECT\DECISIONS.md	10 decisions with the reasoning and what else was considered
Which file does what	PROJECT\ARCHITECTURE.md	How the parts fit together, and a file map
What the project must do	PROJECT\REQUIREMENTS.md	48 requirements and their status
What happened and when	CHANGELOG\CHANGELOG.md	Day by day, newest first

Worked examples

Instead of “why is the page showing the wrong room?”

Check PROJECT\ARCHITECTURE.md for how rooms are paired, then look at the workbook. Do not read the site code yet.

Instead of “can you add a feature?”

Read PROJECT\TODO.md. Do item T-03.

Instead of “why did you do it that way?”

Check PROJECT\DECISIONS.md before answering.

Keeping the files honest

The files are only worth reading if they are true. After any real piece of work, finish with:

Update the project memory before we finish.

I will update the status, add a changelog entry, and adjust the to-do list. CLAUDE.md already tells me to do this, but saying it makes sure. **Routine sync.cmd refreshes do not need it** — those are data updates, not project changes.

What costs tokens, and what does not

The same request, phrased two ways.

Expensive

Have a look at the project and tell me what you think.

Open-ended. I have no choice but to read widely, and most of what I read will not be relevant.

Cheap

Read the status and todo, then suggest what to do next.

Same outcome, a fraction of the reading.

Four habits that keep sessions small

Habit	Why it helps
Name the file when you know it	"Change the email wording" makes me search. "The Message sheet wording" does not.
Say what you do not want touched	"Only the website, leave the workbook alone" halves what I open.
Start a new session for a new topic	A long session carries everything before it. A fresh one starts from the memory files.
Ask for the memory update at the end	A stale status file is worse than none, because I will trust it.

Two things worth knowing

These files do not change the website

They are notes sitting beside the project. Nothing in PROJECT\ or CHANGELOG\ affects what staff see, and sync.cmd ignores them entirely.

The workbook is still the source of truth for data

If the site shows something wrong, the answer is almost always in Proctor Schedule by Date.xlsm, not in the code. The memory files say so, so I will look there first.

If you remember one line from this: open with **"continue the project"** and close with **"update the project memory"**. Everything else is detail.